A House Is Not a Home

The big idea

In this autobiographical story by **Zan Gaylord**, a lonely fourteen-year-old who has just started at a new high school loses his home in a **fire**. Through this loss and the unexpected **kindness** of schoolmates and the community, he learns that a home is made of the **people** who love us, not of walls and things.

Summary

1. At **fourteen**, the narrator starts as a freshman at a new high school. He misses his old friends and teachers, feels lonely, and has not made new friends.
2. One **Sunday afternoon**, while he and his mother are at home, they smell smoke and find the house on **fire**. They run out.
3. His **mother runs back inside** to save some **important papers** and family records. A **firefighter** brings her out safely. The narrator realises how close he came to losing her, and how unimportant possessions are.
4. Everything burns: clothes, school books, keepsakes, photographs. The narrator is also heartbroken because his beloved **cat** is missing.
5. Back at school, he feels awkward and expects nobody to care. Then classmates he barely knew arrive with **school supplies, clothes, books and binders**, and the community gives them help.
6. Later, a woman brings back his **cat**, which had run away in fright and been found. He is overjoyed.
7. He realises he is no longer alone. The kindness of others helps him accept the loss and **adjust to the new school**: "a house is not a home"; love and friendship make a home.

Characters

- **The narrator**: shy, sensitive, lonely; grows through loss into gratitude and openness.
- **The mother**: brave and devoted, risks her life for family papers.
- **Schoolmates and community**: kind and generous.

Themes

- **Loss and recovery**.
- **Kindness of strangers** and the power of community.
- **A home is people, not property**.
- Adjusting to change (new school).

THE TITLE'S MEANING

The title does not say the house was unimportant to the family. It says a house becomes a home only through the love of family and friends.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did the narrator feel lonely at the new school? What did his mother do during the fire? How did his classmates help? What did he learn from the experience?

Quick recap

- Lonely new student; house burns down on a Sunday.
- Mother saves papers; cat missing then returned.
- Classmates' kindness makes him feel at home.

Practice questions

1. How old was the narrator when he started high school?
   (a) Twelve (b) Thirteen (c) Fourteen (d) Sixteen
2. Why was the narrator unhappy at his new school?
   (a) He missed his old friends and felt lonely (b) The teachers were strict (c) He failed his exams (d) The school was far away
3. Why did the narrator's mother run back into the burning house?
   (a) To save the cat (b) To call the fire brigade (c) To find her jewellery (d) To save important papers
4. What did the narrator's schoolmates bring for him?
   (a) Money and food (b) A new house (c) School supplies, clothes and books (d) A puppy
5. What happened to the narrator's cat?
   (a) It died in the fire (b) It was adopted by a neighbour permanently (c) It was never mentioned again (d) It ran away and was later brought back
6. The main message of the story is that
   (a) fires are dangerous (b) love and kindness make a house a home (c) new schools are difficult (d) pets should be kept indoors
7. How did the fire change the narrator's life?

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. see notes